Modern Languages

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Contemporary World

Women in War

1. **Introduction**

In the following essay, we will be covering how women have an approached and contributed to war, especially during World War Two (WW2) but also in past warfare-related events and in current times, taking into consideration the sociological factors that have made an effect on how their experience in war had been different from their male counterparts. The inspiration and one of the many sources we will be using for this work is the book *The Unwomanly Face of War: An Oral History of Women in World War II* Svetlana Alexievich, a Belarusian writer and journalist, that interviews Soviet women who participated in World War II, a forgotten memory.

2. Historical context: WW2 and the role of women at the time

2.1. Quick overview of WW2

World War II was a global armed conflict that took place between 1939 and 1945 and involved directly or indirectly most of the powers of the time. It is considered the largest war in the history of mankind, in terms of the number of nations involved, the territorial dimensions of the conflict, the number of weapons used and the historical consequences. Few nations in the world remained outside the conflict. It occurred in three main scenarios: European, Asian and African. Europe experienced two major alliances: the Axis powers, with Germany, Italy and Japan as main protagonists, and the Allies, with the United States, the United Kingdom, France and Russia, among others.

The German invasion of Poland, which followed the annexation of Austria and Czechoslovakia without any reaction from the Allies, is often taken as a trigger event for World War II. However, the alliance between Poland and France demanded from the latter the declaration of war to the German Third Reich when, after agreement on the division of Polish lands with the then neutral USSR, they crossed the border with their troops. The end of World War II occurred in 1945, in a period that was between the fall of Germany by Soviet forces and the suicide of Adolf Hitler, and the American bombing of the Japanese cities of Hiroshima and Nagasaki with atomic bombs, forcing the immediate unconditional surrender of this country.

In a conflict that blurred the borders between military forces and civilian populations, the Second World War killed 39 million people in Europe alone, half of them civilians; around the world it killed 3% of the population in six years. There were events as traumatic for human civilization as the Jewish Holocaust, the mass death of civilian citizens and the first and only use in history of nuclear weapons of mass destruction.

As consequences of the war, the European powers, except the Soviet Union, lost their leading role in the world. The rivalry between the United States and the Soviet Union would lead to the Cold War, due to their opposing ideological approaches: liberalism and communism. The United Nations (UN) was created to prevent conflicts between powers being resolved by violent means

2.2. The role of women

From the second half of the 19th century, the feminine ideal of women as queen of the home was reinforced. They were perceived as fragile and delicate, ideas that were nourished by the beliefs that they were unfit for demanding physical and intellectual work They were marginalized to the point of almost not considering them as people. Educated for marriage, women were viewed from an «angelization» standard which allowed her to occupy the throne of the home in exchange for practicing virtues such as chastity, self-denial and submission while overseeing washing, cooking, ironing, sewing, taking care of the family, etc. Motherhood was claimed to be the main female function but making it clear that the reproductive act had nothing to do with the enjoyment of sexuality. This feminine ideal continued, fundamentally, during the first half of the twentieth century.

One of the greatest changes of the twentieth century was the incursion of women into social, political, and economic life, and their active participation in all these areas, which was previously denied to them. One of the decisive factors in this change was the world wars, because in many cases women have had to replace men who, by enlisting in the army, delegated their jobs and occupations to women. However, this did not mean they were treated equally in the labor force.

Besides, the question of women's voting rights finally became an issue in the 19th century. Before WW2, women could vote in countries such as New Zealand, Australia, Finland, Norway, Soviet Russia, Canada, Germany, Austria, Poland, Czechoslovakia, the United States and Hungary, Great Britain, Ecuador, South Africa, Brazil, Thailand, Turkey, the Philippines, etc. In a number of those countries, women were initially granted the right to vote in municipal, local or provincial elections, only later they were granted the right to vote in national elections. It was only after WW2 when full women suffrage was introduced into France, Italy, Switzerland, Romania, Yugoslavia, China, India and so on.

While the most famous image of female patriotism during World War II is Rosie the Riveter, women were also involved in other aspects of the war outside of those roles replacing missing men. Hundreds of thousands of women performed combat functions, especially in anti-aircraft units. The Soviet Union, for example, integrated women directly into its army units. The United States, by comparison, chose not to use women in combat because of public opinion and, as in other nations, approximately 350,000 women served as uniformed auxiliaries in non-combatant roles in the U.S. armed forces, including roles such as administration, nurses, truck drivers, mechanics, electricians and auxiliary pilots. The take about women participation in each country was different, so it will be further explored in the following pages.

After the end of the war, the chapter was closed for them women and they stopped being part of the memory. During the war, women did things that were considered "manly" at the time. Their work was needed and valued, then no longer. So, let's analyze and take a closer look into the stories of these women that were brought to light only several decades after thanks to authors like Svetlana Alexievich.

3. The Effect of Gender: How war was different for women because of the way society perceived them

3.1. Difficulties and Opportunities

As previously said, the view society had for woman in the period of the first and second World War was that of caregivers, wives, and housemaids; even though women of middle- or lower-class families were used to working, if it was not needed they were expected to stay at home and take care of their families. Because of this, when WW2 was more in need of their help, it was difficult for society to acknowledge them and to give them equal opportunities to help their countries. In every country their insertion to the war was different, but some things remained the same: the pay gap for industry-related jobs was huge, the women who wanted to joined armed forces were constantly pushed back to do so, their personal hygiene needs were not always met, they had a hard time gaining recognition of any kind during and even after the war, and they were expected to preserve their "femininity" in the most frightening and dangerous situations –as in taking care of their skin, hair, and other things not for health but beauty, using clothes that suited that delicate idea they had of them at the time instead of clothing that would protected them, and so on.

In all countries during WW2, sooner or later, they were in need of the support of women, one of the first countries in which women started to take active part in the war was the Soviet Union: Like portrayed multiple times in the book, soviet women were not required to join the army, yet they volunteered, as they believed their role was just as important as the one their male counterparts had, the Soviet Union was probably one of the most "receiving" places for women who wanted to take part in the war and even when their experiences were equally hard they would still be discriminated by their enemies and their own comrades and officers, the latter would prevent them to join their forces, and even offered food and power for sexual favors to the ones already at their service.

Vera Safronova and Maria Ivanovna (in that order) comment in Alexiévich's novel, about the recruitment:

> In 1941 I finished tenth grade in the Slobodka high school, Kordymsky district. When the war began… I ran to the recruiting office. They sent me home. I went there twice more and was refused twice more. On July 28, the retreating units passed through our Slobodka, and I went to the front with them without any call-up.
>
> We came to the recruiting office; we went in one door at once and were let out another… Where were we going? We didn't know. In the end it was not so important to us what we'd be. So long as it was at the front. Everybody was fighting—and we would be, too.

Likewise, in Europe, the UK called women to work to all different sorts of positions in the war such as mechanics, engineers, munitions workers, air raid wardens, bus and fire engine drivers quite fast, since WWI they were part of the war in more equal parts than in most countries. In the same way, in France women took on important roles, they were especially good spies (liaison agents), and even had specialized combat teams with only women on their lines. Most of the remaining countries waited until there were not enough men to cover all the places needed in the war or never allowed them to participate on front lines in almost any way –like Japan, for example–, and so propaganda started to "convey their patriotism" so they would take on jobs men previously did so the latter could be freed to go to the front, examples of this are the Rosies of Roosevelt and recruiting poster such as "Be A Marine. Free A Marine to Fight" (McEuen, 2016).

In other countries, like Italy during Mussolini's regime, Portugal and Germany throughout most of the war, women had zero to no opportunities to fight alongside men. Hitler ideology did not allow women to leave the home front until the last years of the war, he believed Americans, British, and French people to be "degenerates" for letting their women fight, he thought their job was to concentrate in being good wives and mothers, and to have babies for the Third Reich. On Portugal, they did not allow women to go to the front but did not made such strong declaration either, while Mussolini only perceived them as child-bearers, and even proclaimed legal measures to have institutions dedicated to the "improvement" of the Italian race directed to women, maternity, and childhood.

Nonetheless, by 1943 when Mussolini's regime ended, Women's Defense Groups began in Milan to coincide with the National Committee of the Liberation of Northern Italy, they contributed the most on grassroots mobilization and helped put women in political roles, mostly through the Italian Catholic Women and Italian Women unions (Lynch, 2015). In the United States, the propaganda had made an effect and even the most "masculine jobs" started to be carried away by women, from farm laborers to the creation of the first women-led air force, The Women Airforce Service Pilots (WASP), by that year more than 310,000 women worked in the air force. Even the Germans had to allow women in their lines, by the end of the war 500,000 German women had served in one way or the other in the military (Alexiévich, 2017).

To this day, the western world had never seen such a large involvement of women in a war such as this before. Nonetheless, most problems like unequal pay gaps (skilled female workers earned around 23 dollars less than their male counterparts weekly, even less for women of color who also went through psychological and physical attacks because of race in factories), childcare for working mothers only took care of around 10% of the children that needed that support, and overall the industry was expected to continue to be dominated by men.

In that time, the message to women the government wanted to convey was that their inclusion to the work and "men-related" activities would only be needed while the war lasted, "this was both a promise and an order, suggesting that the war and the opportunities it created would end simultaneously" (McEuen, 2016). By the end of the war, a lot of women were fired in industries, some never got recognized for their work in the force, and generally both men from their countries and the government expect them to return quietly to the life they had before but most felt that their experiences prevented them from stepping back into the structure society was following before the war, especially in countries where they had achieved political influence of any kind, or started creating armed forces for women before the end of WWII. This opened a door for women's right to develop in the following years.

3.2. The sociology of "femininity" and "masculinity" during the war years

As previously mentioned, in various countries women started to take part in what was seen as "masculine labor", this created many sociological changes leading to women becoming stronger and respect in those areas while also reinforcing some other views society had regarding femininity. For example, as pointed out in Alexiévich's book "A linguistic problem even emerged: no feminine gender had existed till then for the words "tank driver," "infantryman," "machine gunner," because women had never done that work", but even when the room was made for women to take on most of these

positions (yet not all), propaganda like the Rosies tried to give out an image of working women that preserved feminine aspects like the use of make-up.

This led to two main reactions from women: the first one was directed to follow the advice and instructions advertisements and propaganda instructed: to pay attention to their skincare, personal hygiene, hair, and so on in order no to "lose their femininity", in the U.S.A. cosmetics were never rationed because of this and in all countries women would either refuse to use, or be denied or be treated poorly because of the use uniforms that could have better protected them in factories or in military positions, as can be seen in the next excerpt from Alexiévich's book and photos from women in different places of the world:

Rosie the Riveter propaganda. Source: https://www.nationalww2museum.org/students-teachers/student-resources/research-starters/women-wwii

Resistance fighter Simone Ségouin in Paris in 1944. Source: https://english.elpais.com/elpais/2016/10/11/inenglish/1476196791_317656.html

Women factory workers at the Colt Manufacturing Company making barrels for the M1911. Source: https://library.ccsu.edu/dighistFall16/exhibits/show/industry-ct-ww1/women-in-the-factories

Commented by Maria Nikolaevna in Alexiévich's novel:

> The women shout, cover themselves: "Soldiers are coming!" They couldn't tell we were girls: we had boys' haircuts and wore army uniforms. Another time we went to the toilet, and the women brought a policeman. We asked him, "So where do we go?"
> He then shouted at those women, "These are girls!"
> "What kind of girls, these are soldiers…"

The second main reaction women had was exactly the opposite, they wanted to look more like their masculine counterparts so they could be more respected in their military jobs and, therefore, have more opportunities to fight alongside them. For this, German soldiers at the beginning of the war wrote about soviet women soldiers as "ferocious riflewomen" [Flintenweiber], "Bolshevik beasts" and "amazons devoid of femininity." (De Jesus, 2017). Likewise, some women even hid their sexual identity in order to have certain positions, like Rudenko-Sheveleva exposes in the novel and as can be seen in the following photos:

> A woman in the navy… That was something forbidden, even unnatural. People thought it would be bad luck for a ship… I wrote a letter to Voroshilov himself, asking to be accepted in the Leningrad Artillery School. They accepted me only on his personal order. The only girl. When I finished the school, they still wanted me to stay on dry land. Then I stopped telling them that I was a woman.

Women in Germany's armed forced. Source: https://www.theatlantic.com/photo/2011/09/world-war-ii-women-at-war/100145/

Soviet woman soldiers in WW2I. Source: https://www.theparisreview.org/blog/2017/07/25/we-were-a-cheerful-cargo/

4. Recognition of their work

When it comes to women veterans of WW2, the following question arises: How did they experience the come back home and where they praised as much as the men were? By the time Alexievich came to talk to the interviewed veterans, numerous had given up trust of ever getting to tell their stories. Their stories had been cleared aside for so long that they were incredibly happy to have someone listen and record their memories:

> I want to speak… to speak! To speak it all out! Finally, somebody wants to hear us. For so many years we said nothing, even at home we said nothing. For decades. The first year, when I came back from the war, I talked and talked. Nobody listened. So, I shut up…It's good that you've come along. I've been waiting all the while for somebody; I knew somebody would come. Had to come. (Natalya Ivanovna Sergeeva – Private, Nurse-aide)

More than one million women joined the military with around half of them being in active combat roles. When the war ended, they had wanted to come home proud of their achievements and stand next to their male comrades, but their country failed them and instead of being praised and given recognition like men soldiers, they were harshly shamed:

> How did the Motherland meet us? I can't speak without sobbing… It was forty years ago, but my cheeks still burn. The men said nothing, but the women…They shouted to us, "We know what you did there! You lured our men with your young c—-! Army whores… Military bitches…" They insulted us in all possible ways… The Russian vocabulary is rich… (Klavdia S—va – Sniper)

It was made clear to them that being a soldier was not possible if you were a decent woman:

> When I put on a dress for the first time, I flooded myself with tears. I didn't recognize myself in the mirror. We had spent four years in trousers. There was no one I could tell that I had been wounded, that I had a concussion. Try telling it, and who will give you a job then, who will marry you? We were silent as fish. We never acknowledged to anybody that we had been at the front. (Valentina Pavlovna Chudaeva – Sergeant, Commander of Anti-Aircraft Artillery)

Hiding their medals away, some women did their best to make their past as soldiers disappear. They did not dare to parade and wear their badges even though men did. In extreme cases, some women destroyed their documents, and this made impossible to claim veteran benefits and even moved far away trying their best to stay hidden. It was in some other cases that women veterans were proud given that they had fought alongside their husbands making it easier to not be shamed.

Due to the negative view of women veterans at the time, we can assume that most of them didn't benefit from veteran programs, and if they did, many years later, these programs did not cater to their specific necessities. We found an abstract to a research paper stating the following:

> Most of today's 1.7 million women veterans in the U.S obtain all or most of their medical care outside the VA health care system (The Veterans Health Administration, the largest integrated health care system in the United States), where their veteran status is rarely recognized or acknowledged. Several aspects of women's military service have been associated with adverse psychological and physical outcomes, and failure to assess women's veteran status, their deployment status, and military trauma history could delay identifying or treating such conditions. Yet few clinicians know of women's military history—or of military service's impact on women's subsequent health and wellbeing. (Murdoch, M., Bradley, A., Mather, S.H. *et al.* Women and war, 2006).

During the years of the war, both talking about WW1 and WW2, lots of men and women were recognized with badges and other public forms to show to society and their follow comrades that they had an important role on the war, but were they equally recognized? Regarding the U.S.A. and France, for example, we have three cases regarding the Distinguished Service Cross, a medal given for heroism in combat with an armed enemy force, that show how the rewarding system was not totally equal: Virginia Hall, Thomas Troy Handy, and Jane Kendeigh and her fellow nurses from the first Navy flight nurse evacuation missions in the U.S.

Virginia Hall was a "civilian" woman that worked as a liaison agent in both the U.S. and France, she was awarded the Distinguished Service Cross after the war ended because of her multiple acts of sabotage against German forces, and the training a command of three FFI Battalions alongside two commanders in France after she had lost a leg and without caring that she was already well known by the Gestapo. She was one of the few women that ever got this recognition. On the other hand, we have Kendeigh and other nurses, which evacuated more than one million military patients during incredibly dangerous situations in different war fronts during the WW2, and never got any type of medal for their work. For the last part, we have men from the military that were equally important for their roles but did not have to go to such extends to get recognition for their work, like Thomas Troy Handy, who received this award after

voluntarily joining an important attack while his troops where in France and accomplished solve that situation along-side his comrades successfully; in other words, he received the award for doing his work with courage, as Kendeigh did and was never awarded for.

5. Conclusion

Thankfully, there are more and more veteran programs and resources available, as well as books like War's Unwomanly Face that change the portrayal of women in war, giving them the deserved visibility to their work and stories that otherwise would have been lost in time. The focus should also be on the women fighting in the fronts of the current ongoing conflicts, such as Ukrainian women joining the military amid Russia's invasion. According to military officials, around 50,000 women are serving in the Ukrainian armed forces in combat and non-combat roles

> I am glad to be here because sometimes women are underestimated in the Ukrainian army. But we are doing quite well. We sometimes have more strength and we can do many jobs. We are dynamic and we inspire patriotism for our warriors to fight to the end. (Says 23-year-old Diana, serving in the Ukrainian military, who goes by the nickname Sledgehammer, when asked what it was like to be a woman in the army in the middle of a war).

As many women continue to join the armed forces and to help in this kind of situations voluntarily, we can only hope they are given equal treatment and don not have to face the discrimination previous women had and can play the roles in defending their nations in the military, work-force, political leaders, or any other way they choose honorably.

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